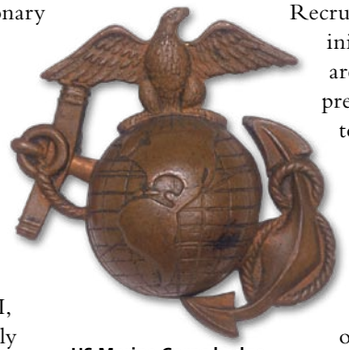


Reconnaissance team
A platoon commander from the 1st United States Marine Division uses a radio during operations in Vietnam *(above)*. The Marines' chief machine-gun was the general-purpose M60 *(right)*.

THE FIRST AMERICAN GROUND FORCES deployed in offensive combat operations against the Viet Cong and the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) were the US Marines who came ashore at Da Nang on the coast of South Vietnam on 8 March 1965. The choice of the Marines to spearhead US involvement in Vietnam reflected both their status as an elite fighting force and their traditional role as agents of US overseas intervention. The following six years of warfare were to test the Marines' endurance to the limit.

The US Marines who served in Vietnam were inheritors of a long and proud tradition. The Marine Corps traced its origins back to the two battalions of Continental Marines established in 1775 to serve as soldiers on board naval vessels during the American Revolutionary War. In the course of the 19th and early 20th centuries, the Marines developed a role as an overseas intervention force – one of their notable actions was to seize the harbour at Guantanamo Bay in Cuba during the 1898 Spanish-American War. They served with distinction in World War I, for which they were considerably better prepared than the US Army. By World War II, the Marines were developing techniques of amphibious warfare that were applied successfully during the island-hopping campaign against the Japanese in the Pacific from 1942 to 1945. The Korean War subsequently confirmed their claim to be the toughest American infantry force – a claim with which the US Army naturally did not agree.



US Marine Corps badge
The eagle and anchor symbolize the Marine Corps' air and sea capabilities.

TRAINING AN ELITE

The quality of the Marines as fighting men depended largely upon the quality of their training. At the time of the Vietnam War, the Marine Corps was, at it is today, a self-contained all-arms formation, with its own artillery, helicopters, and fixed-wing aircraft. But the infantry was the focus of Marine operations (Marine aircraft were intended primarily for close air support) and all Marine recruits had to undergo training as riflemen. The rigours of the 13-week Marine "boot camp" at the Parris Island Recruit Depot, and at the Corps' other initial training facility at San Diego, are legendary. Gruelling marches, press-ups, and runs are executed to the constant accompaniment of aggressively yelled orders and abuse from instructors. The process culminates in the "Crucible", a 54-hour field training exercise in which the recruit is allowed a maximum of eight hours' sleep. Successful recruits then go on to other camps for regular infantry training, with an emphasis on accurate shooting at long range, and to learn specialist skills. A sign at Parris Island proclaims: "The deadliest weapon in the world – a Marine and his rifle."

The Marine infantryman sent to Vietnam – the "grunt" – was typically no more than 18 to 20 years old. Recruits came from all over the US, although there was a tendency for more to hail from the rural Mid-West and South. Fully racially integrated since the later stages of the Korean War, the Marines attracted many African-Americans, who found in the armed forces a better employment opportunity and relatively equal treatment at a time when civil rights were a hotly contested issue in the US.



M60 MACHINE-GUN